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Every year, Diwali makes people break their piggy banks and splurge on a smorgasborg of technology products. Most people opt for the latest, fastest and coolest gadgets of the season; caught up in a shopping frenzy of sorts, thanks to the hundreds of seemingly attractive deals on offer. However, are those purchases the most prudent ones? Are those deals the best? Maybe not. In this article we'll try to give you some practical advice across popular categories to enable you to make the wisest decisions.

Devices on the go

Smartphones and tablets, together are the most sought-after gadgets this time around. This is consistent with the findings from our Digit survey. The category has seen so many new offerings off late. In tablets, you have several Android Honeycomb devices apart from the ubiquitous iPad 2. While as far as smartphones go, there are now battles being fought in specifications. Where just a few months ago, you had 1 GHz as the norm now you have dual-



Dual core phones - the way to go

core mobile devices from several manufacturers. When it comes to smartphones, based on our analysis of trends, if you are going in for a high-end phone i.e. upwards of ₹24,000 our advice would be to go the extra mile, and go for a dual-core solution with a good GPU. The reason is pretty simple, future proofing. Requirements of future operating systems and even high-end applications such as games will compel you to possess a high spec phone



Shop Smart this Diwali

Practical advice to make the best purchases this season

in the near future. You might have already heard of the TegraZone game store for Tegra 2 powered phones and tablets.

If you plan to purchase a BlackBerry, your best bet would be to hold off on that purchase until there are true QNX devices out from RIM. As it's been widely reported, the new Android app layer in RIM's QNX-based operating systems will let users access the ever-expanding Android ecosystem. The BlackBerry Colt, which is to be launched somewhere in the first quarter of 2012, is the QNX phone to look forward to. QNX will give you the best of both worlds - BlackBerry's efficient push mail and messenger, with the usability glory of Android apps.

When it comes to tablets, Agent 001 will give you the gyaan you'll need about this category. The crux of tablet purchase lies in the usage pattern that

you're likely to follow. Most people who have had tablets for some time now use it as a portable screen around their house, which is Wi-Fi enabled. Very few actually go in for a 3G tablet and use it effectively while on the move, especially with the hassles involved in cutting SIM cards for tablets such as the iPad 2.

Hence, the best advice before purchasing a tablet would be to think about how you intend to use it and for how much time. As for whether it can replace a laptop, most people will reply with a resounding "no". However, if you're just a social networking junkie, who likes his web videos and the occasional email, there's no reason why a tablet won't work for you.

Laptops

Laptop-buying mostly depends on the configuration. There are literally hundreds of permutations and combinations that are possible in this space. Still, there are a few guidelines that you can follow as buying rules. When



Look for the new generation Sandy Bridge mobile processors

looking at the specifications of your prospective laptop, you'll find the processor names to be similar i.e. Core i3, Core i5. However, check for the exact part number. If it's a three-digit number such as Intel Core i3-380M, then it belongs to the older generation. What you would ideally want is a next generation Sandy Bridge processor also named Core i3 or i5, but with a four-digit part number such as Core i3-2310M especially if you engage in processor-intensive tasks like encoding or rendering. Another tidbit of advice is to no longer consider the 10.1 inch netbook form-factor seriously; at least not with the current generation of Atom processors that they come with. A better bet would be to wait for the Oak Trail

Smart Tip

For more Diwali shopping advice, check out our November 2010 issue. Much of the advice has stood the test of time and holds true this Diwali too.